

NEUROPLASTICITY · SUPER SKILL · BRAIN BUILDER · THE
MASTER RESOURCE

Meet Your Brain Town.

The very first idea in Daniel's Diaries — where your child learns that their brain is a town, they are the town planner, and every building and road in it can be understood, cared for, and built.

Everything else in Daniel's Diaries is built on top of this resource. It gives your child their first shared language for how their brain works: the roads, the buildings, and the quiet, powerful job of being the planner. This guide is here to help you hand it over well.

START HERE

AGES 5-11

A GUIDED INTRODUCTION TO DO AT HOME



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COMPANION TO

The Daniel's Diaries platform
danielsdiaries.com.au
Where your child becomes the town planner

START HERE · BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE

Your brain is a town. You are the planner.

Children are not born knowing that their thoughts, feelings, and actions are connected, or that they have any say over them. When a child believes they simply *are* angry, shy, or scared, those words start to feel like the weather: something that happens to them. The town idea changes that. It hands the child a map and a job. **They are no longer the storm. They are the person quietly planning where the roads go.**

A road is: a pathway in the brain, built by being travelled.

A motorway is: a habit or reaction so well practised it runs on its own.

The planner is: your child, learning to notice the roads and choose what to build.

The town is not just a sweet story. It is a faithful, child sized version of how the brain genuinely learns. Every time we think, feel, or do something, a set of brain cells fire together and pass the signal along a tiny pathway. The more often that pathway is used, the stronger and faster it becomes. A path walked once is faint. A path walked a thousand times becomes automatic, travelled without a second thought. That capacity has a real name in the research: **neuroplasticity**. Brains are built to change, and a child's brain is building fastest of all.

Two things make the metaphor work, and both are deliberate. It is concrete and visual, which is how children this age think best — an invisible process becomes a place they can draw, point to, and move around in. And it puts the child *outside* the problem. A worried road is something you can stand beside and look at together, rather than something the child has to be. *That small distance is where change, and a great deal of relief from shame, begins.*

A NOTE FROM DANIEL

The brain cells that talk to each other a lot end up holding hands and building a road. The more they chat, the bigger the road gets. And every town needs a planner to decide what gets built next. In your child's brain town, that planner is them. Pretty clever, hey?

— Daniel, Road Builder



MORE THAN ROADS · EVERY TOWN HAS BUILDINGS

The buildings of the town.

Roads carry the traffic, but the town also has buildings, and each one has a job. Each building is a real part of the brain, translated into a place your child can picture. Knowing the buildings helps the whole family talk about hard moments without blame — because a building working hard is very different from a child being naughty.



The Town Hall

PREFRONTAL CORTEX

Where planning, decisions, and impulse control happen. It is the last building finished in every child's town — still under construction well into the twenties. When a child "knows the rule but doesn't follow it", the Town Hall was simply not the building in charge in that moment.



The Fire Station

AMYGDALA · THE ALARM

The town's alarm system, always scanning for danger. It is fast, loud, and not very accurate — it would rather ring for nothing than miss something real. When the alarm rings, everyone in the Town Hall evacuates, and no decisions get made until it is quiet again.



The Memory Warehouse

HIPPOCAMPUS

Where new learning gets filed and old learning gets fetched. Deliveries only get processed when the town is calm — while the alarm is ringing, nothing new goes on the shelves. That is why nobody learns a lesson in the middle of a big feeling.



The Body Signal Station

INTEROCEPTION

The station that sends messages from the body: hungry, tired, worried, busting. In many children, and especially many neurodivergent children, the messages arrive late or garbled — a feeling can be a full alarm before the child ever noticed it coming.

There is also the **Social Hub**, where reading people and connecting happens, and the **road network** itself, which carries messages between every building. In some towns certain buildings run on reduced staff or the roads between them are narrower. *That never means the town cannot thrive. It means the town needs a planner, and adults who understand the map.*

"When the fire alarm is ringing, the Town Hall is empty. Calm the alarm first. Talk to the planner later."

THE CONVERSATION · AN OFFER, NOT A LESSON

How to introduce it, in your own voice.

Sit beside your child, not across from them. Keep it light, leave room for them to wonder, and stop while they are still interested. Five minutes is plenty. This conversation belongs to a calm, ordinary moment, not a hard one — **you cannot teach a town planner anything while the alarm is going off.**

1 Open a door, gently

Low pressure language keeps a child curious instead of cornered. *"I learned something today about how brains work. I reckon yours is going to like it. Want to hear?"* If they say not now, that is fine. The door stays open.

2 Plant the town

"Your brain is a bit like a whole town. The roads are your thoughts and the things you do. When you do something lots and lots of times, that road gets bigger and easier, like a main street everyone uses."

3 Hand over the job

"Here is the best bit. Every town has a town planner who decides where the roads go. In your brain town, that planner is you. You get to choose which roads to build bigger."

4 Let them find a road

"What is one road you reckon you travel heaps? Something you do without even thinking?"

Brushing teeth, asking for a snack, a worry at bedtime. Any answer is the right answer. You are just helping them notice a road exists.

AVOID

Language that closes the town down.

"See, so you can just choose to stop."

"That is a bad road. We need to get rid of it."

"Why do you keep building that road?"

USE

Language that opens the map together.

"I wonder which roads are biggest in your town."

"That road has had a lot of practice, hey."

"Want to be the planner on this one?"

DO THIS TOGETHER

Map your town.

This is the first thing your child ever builds in Daniel's Diaries, and it is theirs to keep. Grab some paper and whatever they like to draw with — a bigger sheet is even better if they get going.

10–15 minutes

No wrong answers

Keep the drawing

Building the map

- **Draw the town.** A few houses, a park, a school, a dog kennel for Daniel. It does not need to be neat. It is their town.
- **Add the buildings.** Draw the Town Hall where the planning happens, the Fire Station that rings the alarm, and the Memory Warehouse where the learning gets stored. Naming the buildings now gives the whole family shared words for hard moments later.
- **Add the big roads.** Ask, *"What are some things you do nearly every day?"* Draw each one as a nice wide road. These are the main streets and motorways.
- **Add one tiny new road.** Ask, *"Is there a road you would like to build a bit bigger? Something you are still learning?"* Draw it small, like a little track. Name it together.
- **Be the planner.** Have them sign the map as the town planner. That signature is the whole point.

If your child finds drawing hard

The drawing is the doorway, not the goal. Build the town in blocks or toys, walk it out as paths across the lounge room floor, or simply talk the roads out loud while you scribe. A child who narrates their town is doing exactly the same thinking as one who draws it.

The question is never, "Did they draw it well?"

The question is, "Do they know the town is theirs?"

AFTER TODAY · EVERYDAY LANGUAGE

Let the town live in **your everyday talk.**

A metaphor only works if it gets used. You do not need a session for this. You need the odd, well placed sentence, dropped into ordinary moments, so the language quietly becomes the family's own.

WHEN SOMETHING GETS EASIER

"You're getting better at that!"

TRY THE TOWN

"Look at that, your getting ready road is turning into

WHEN SOMETHING IS STILL HARD

"Come on, you know how to do this!"

TRY THE TOWN

"That road is brand new. It just needs a few more

WHEN THEY MANAGE A TRICKY MOMENT

"Good boy / good girl!"

TRY THE TOWN

"You just chose a different road there. Nice

WHEN A BIG REACTION SHOWS UP

Correcting it in the heat of the moment.

TRY THE TOWN, LATER

"That was a big, fast motorway, hey. Want to look

"Warmth carries the idea further than accuracy ever will. If today plants nothing more than *my brain can change, and I have a say in it*, you have done the whole job."

WHAT COMES NEXT

The next roads on **the map.**

Next · Naming the Feeling

Building the feelings words, and the body clues that come with them, so your child can spot a road before it gets big.

Then · Building a Calm Road

Choosing and practising one calm down tool, so the new road is sealed and ready before it is ever needed.

A NOTE FROM AIMEE · BEFORE YOU GO

to build.

You have just handed your child something most adults were never given: a kind, accurate picture of their own mind, and a job inside it. From here, every skill in Daniel's Diaries is another building, another road, another quiet trip down a track that is slowly becoming a street.

You will not get the words perfect, and you do not need to. Children forgive a clumsy metaphor far more easily than they forgive feeling judged. Hold it lightly, keep it warm, and let the town belong to them. Some of your child's biggest roads were built early, for good reasons, often to keep them safe. We honour that. We never bulldoze a road. We build new ones beside the old, at the child's pace, and let the travelling do the rest.

THE CORE MESSAGE, FOR YOUR CHILD

"Your brain is a town, and you are the planner."

"Big roads were built by being used. New roads start small."

"When the alarm rings, we calm the town first."

"You get to choose what your town builds next."

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